Methotrexate for Ectopic Pregnancy

Treatment, follow-up, and recovery guide — what to expect during non-surgical ectopic pregnancy management

❓ WHAT IS AN ECTOPIC PREGNANCY?

An ectopic pregnancy occurs when a fertilized egg implants **outside the uterus** — most commonly in a fallopian tube. It cannot survive and must be treated promptly.

- 📊 Affects ~1 in 50 pregnancies (2%)
- 🏥 Medical emergency if tube ruptures — requires immediate surgery
- 🔬 Diagnosed with blood hCG levels and transvaginal ultrasound
- ✅ When caught early, **methotrexate** can treat it non-surgically

🚨 **Seek immediate care if you have severe pelvic pain, shoulder tip pain, or feeling faint — these may indicate rupture.**

💉 HOW METHOTREXATE WORKS

- 🧬 Methotrexate is a medication that **stops rapidly dividing cells** (the developing pregnancy tissue)
- 💉 Given as a single IM injection (rarely split-dose)
- 📅 Most effective when hCG is <5,000 mIU/mL and no cardiac activity on ultrasound
- ⏰ Takes **days to weeks** for hCG to decline to zero

Who Is a Candidate?

- ✅ Hemodynamically stable (not in shock)
- ✅ Small ectopic (<3.5 cm), no rupture
- ✅ Able to follow up reliably for monitoring
- ✅ Normal liver, kidney, and bone marrow function
- ❌ Not for: rupture, heart activity present, very high hCG, or immunocompromised

📅 FOLLOW-UP SCHEDULE

After injection, your hCG must be monitored closely. You may see a temporary RISE in hCG days 1–4 — this is normal and does not mean treatment failure.

Day 4	Blood draw for hCG — baseline post-injection level
Day 7	Second hCG — must drop **≥15%** from Day 4 to confirm success
Weekly	Continue weekly hCG until level reaches zero (may take 4–6 weeks)

⚠️ If hCG does NOT drop ≥15% by Day 7, a **second dose** or surgery may be required. Do not miss your lab appointments!

⚠️ RESTRICTIONS DURING TREATMENT

🚫 **AVOID Until hCG = Zero:**

- NO Alcohol — increases liver toxicity risk
- NO Folic acid / prenatal vitamins — counteracts methotrexate
- NO NSAIDs (ibuprofen, naproxen) — increases side effects
- NO Unprotected sex or attempts to conceive — wait at least **3 months** after hCG reaches zero
- NO Sun exposure without sunscreen — photosensitivity
- NO Strenuous activity — rupture risk

Common Side Effects (Usually Mild)

- 🤢 Nausea, vomiting, mouth sores
- 😔 Fatigue, mild abdominal cramping (Days 3–7)
- 📈 Temporary hCG rise (Days 1–4) — DO NOT PANIC

🧡 We Are With You Through This

An ectopic pregnancy is a loss, and it's okay to grieve. Methotrexate is highly effective when used in appropriate candidates — most women can go on to have successful pregnancies afterward. Please never hesitate to call us if you develop new or worsening pain, heavy bleeding, or feel unwell. **Emergency line: (281) 557-0300** — available to you 24/7. 🧡